THE TASKMASTER

Ravneet Kaur, *60*
Chairperson, Competition Commission of India

RAVNEET KAUR HAD NO TIME TO SOAK IN the sense of personal accomplishment when she took charge of the Competition Commission of India (CCI) in May 2023 as its first woman head. The organisation's work was poised at a rather critical juncture. Investigating transnational technology giants like Google, Apple and Meta for allegedly engaging in anti-competitive conduct was no small matter. Nor was safeguarding small businesses against predatory pricing from ecommerce giants like Amazon and Flipkart. There was a massive backlog of cases too—in fact, the CCI had been functioning without a head and with just two members for several months before Ravneet joined it.

The first priority was to clear pending cases. "Before my appointment, a significant backlog had accumulated, primarily due to a lack of quorum. By streamlining processes and ensuring transparent and timely decision-making, we have effectively addressed this backlog," she says. What further helped the commission was that the Centre also amended the competition law, giving more enforcement power to contain anti-competitive behaviour. Another key task for her has been fast-tracking the review of notified mergers, acquisitions and amalgamations (M&As). "We have streamlined the evaluation processes, reducing the turnaround time for M&A approvals, thus contributing to the overall vigour of the economy," she says.

A Punjab-cadre IAS officer, Ravneet in her 34-year-long career has held various roles with the government, including joint secretary in the Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion and chairperson and managing director of the India Tourism Development Corporation. The project closest to her heart, she says, was when she created the action plan for various government departments and ministries to propel India's manufacturing and services sector under the Make in India initiative.

Ravneet believes that as a bureaucrat, her biggest responsibility is being fair and just in her decision-making. She belongs to a family of bureaucrats and says her family supported her fully and shared her goals as their own. Her mother is her main source of inspiration. ■

-Sonal Khetarpal



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ACCOMPLISHMENT

As the first woman to head India's anti-trust body, Ravneet Kaur has taken a number of steps to clear pending cases and is looking into alleged unfair business practices by technology giants

TOP NOTCH ADVICE

"My mother would always tell me that you have to be at the top. Only then you can move ahead in life"

↘ LIGHTER MOMENTS

Kaur likes to do gardening, meditation and going for walks

↘ BEST MEMORIES

Her years in the US—especially the bright colours of the autumn—when she was a student at Cornell University